

Originally Processed With FOIA(s):  
2009-0275-S

FOIA Number:  
2009-0275-S

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**OA/ID Number:** 91112  
**Folder ID Number:** 91112-001

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**Folder Title:**  
Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 8/2/90 - 8/20/90

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THE WHITE HOUSE  
WASHINGTON

**MEMCON**

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Call to Prime Minister Thatcher of  
the United Kingdom (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President  
Margaret Thatcher, Prime Minister  
Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff (Notetaker)

DATE, TIME August 20, 1990, 9:16 - 9:26 a.m.  
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President initiated the call. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Hello, George. How are you? (U)

The President: Fine. I am delighted to hear your voice. I just wanted to call to mention one or two things and compare notes.  
(U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: We are both thinking in the same direction. I just had some political and military advisors here.  
(U)

The President: Our ambassador to the United Nations tells me that we may be in reach of a new resolution that would endorse the use of force. I hope he is successful. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: It is absolutely vital. Otherwise there will be no way to enforce the sanctions, and we would look foolish. (U)

The President: On the question of those ships refusing to stop, it is my view, Margaret, that we must stop them. We cannot permit the first challenge to be breached. We would have to do it under Article 51, with the Emir requesting to have UN sanctions enforced. Even absent UN action, we cannot permit those ships to go by. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: I agree. We were saying this morning that the UN must agree to the use of force. It is the only way to bring Saddam Husayn to task. (U)

The President: I agree. I hope you are working with the Soviets and especially the Chinese so that they will instruct their representatives to support the resolution. Our ability to deal with the Chinese, thanks to Congress, is greatly diminished. But it is very important. I hope all friendly governments will agree. (U)

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Prime Minister Thatcher: I asked the Chinese Ambassador in this afternoon. He used to be in America and is a very able man. He was born and brought up in America, so he will be the first to understand. (Ø)

The President: That is very good news, knowing that you can be very persuasive. It would be a very timely message, but if the talks in the UN stall, we cannot permit those two ships into port. (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: I accept that. You and I take the same view that having 51 and the Emir's request, we have the authority. It would be better with a UN approach. (Ø)

The President: Right. It would be much, much better. We are stepping up our numbers over there. Something has to happen. We cannot just stand pat. I have heard different views regarding how long it will take for sanctions to take hold. Ozal thinks they will have an effect soon. What are your views? (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: It depends on how well the sanctions are enforced. It will take some time, but the action itself is important and has an effect on the Iraqi people. We must have full authority to use force. It is the only way to bring Saddam Husayn to task. (Ø)

The President: Is your UN Ambassador optimistic? Ours seems to be. (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: He wasn't on the first resolution, which was too wide. He thinks we can win the second. Two things need to be kept in mind: to protect the oil supplies of the West and the security of the region. The rulers of the Gulf states are pretty concerned. We're going to send more, and I gather you are sending more to the Emirates. (Ø)

The President: Yes. We have some there and have gotten assurances that they will be cordially received. But there are still questions as to what Saddam Husayn will do. Husayn is nutty. It wouldn't be prudent for him to attack Saudi Arabia, but it's hard to know what he will do. (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: He is playing psychological warfare with his broadcasts. We need to make the case that after eight years of war with Iran, he is one Moslem who attacks another. He did so with Iran. He would do it with Saudi Arabia, as he did with Kuwait, and he will do it again. For us, protecting our oil supplies means doing all we can to keep friendly governments in place. (Ø)

The President: I am pleased that we look at it the same way. I wanted you to know that we are encouraged about the UN; but regardless, we cannot let ships skip through. (Ø)

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Prime Minister Thatcher: I agree. We would all look stupid. I don't like bothering you, but I do believe that we must stay in close touch. So I may be calling again. (Ø)

The President: Do, do. I am available any time night or day.  
(U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: We will be sending a few more things to the Gulf. (Ø)

-- End of Conversation --

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